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A cone-based chess set

In the third article in his series, **Mike Darlow** turns a chess set based on the cone

My pieces turned from blackwood (*Acacia melanoxylon*) and European ash (*Fraxinus excelsior*)

The design of anything reflects both the designer's objectives and the constraints that the designer willingly accepts or is forced to accept. When I design a chess set, I believe that a chess-playing stranger should be able to use that set without explanation or the possibility of confusion. And being a woodturner of acceptable standard but an indifferent woodcarver, I usually design all my sets' pieces to be turned, and to have little or no applied carving.

My intention in this article was to create a design with great playability and consistent set and piece signatures. I sized my set design for a board with 50mm × 50mm squares.

Conical lower sections are a feature of many chess sets; for example, Peter Toepfer's later 19th-century set (see *Turned Chessmen*, figure 4.7). I adopted the cone as my set's signature, and it is present in all six pieces.

The features of my piece signatures are:

- My king has the conical set signature, surmounted by a stylised arched crown following the Staunton precedent.
- My queen surmounts the cone with an orb.
- The knight has a section cut from a turned and profiled ring. My ring's cross section features the conical/triangular set signature.
- The pieces' heights conform to the Staunton norm.

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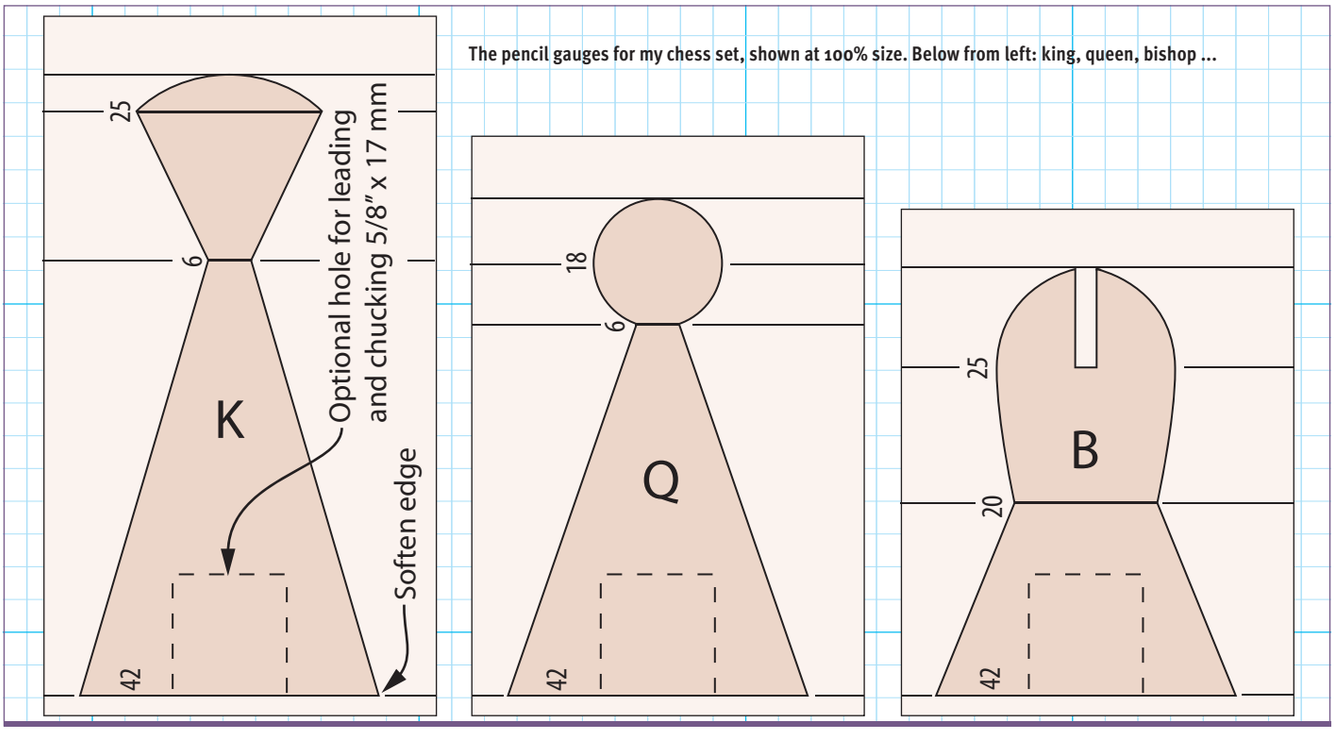

The pencil gauges for my chess set, shown at 100% size. Below from left: king, queen, bishop ...

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